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Ismail: The Firstborn Son and the Sacrifice That Was Returned

The Story of Prophet Ismail (إسماعيل) in the Quran and Islamic Tradition

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Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

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Introduction

Ismail (عليه السلام) is the prophet who was nearly sacrificed. He is the son who lay face down on the stone and said to his father: do as you are commanded. He is the boy who grew up in a barren valley with no water, no people, and no resources -- placed there by his father at Allah's command. He is the young man who helped his father raise the walls of the Kaaba, the first house of worship dedicated to Allah on earth. And he is the ancestor of the final prophet, Muhammad, the one whose lineage runs through the Arab people of Makkah back to Ibrahim.

The Quran tells Ismail's story not as a standalone narrative but as part of Ibrahim's. Ismail appears in the Quran as a son, a builder, a prophet, and a link in the chain. His individual story is less detailed than Ibrahim's, but his significance is enormous: he is the bridge between Ibrahim and Muhammad, the one who carries the covenant from the father of nations to the final messenger.

The most dramatic moment in Ismail's life -- the near-sacrifice -- is told in Surah As-Saffat, and the Quran's account is breathtaking in its compression. In a few verses, the entire trial unfolds: the dream, the conversation, the submission, the knife, the ransom. Two sentences capture the climax:

"So when they had both submitted and he put him down upon his forehead, We called to him: O Ibrahim, you have fulfilled the dream" (37:103-104).

Both submitted. Father and son. Together. This is the Quran's portrait of Ismail: a young man whose faith matched his father's, whose submission was as complete as Ibrahim's, and whose willingness to give his life for Allah made him -- with his father -- the Quran's ultimate example of what it means to be a Muslim.

This book traces Ismail's story through the Quran: his birth, the settlement in Makkah, the sacrifice, the building of the Kaaba, his prophethood, and his legacy as the ancestor of Muhammad. It is the eighth light in the NurOne - The Prophets series -- the light that was offered and returned, the light that built the House, the light that carries the covenant forward.

Chapter 1: Ismail in the Quran

Ismail (عليه السلام) is mentioned by name 12 times in the Quran across 10 surahs. His story is woven into Ibrahim's narrative, but several passages give him independent significance.

Surah As-Saffat (37:99-113) -- The sacrifice narrative, the most dramatic event in Ismail's life. Though the Quran does not name the son in this passage, the majority of scholars identify him as Ismail.

Surah Al-Baqarah (2:125-129) -- The Kaaba, Ibrahim's prayer, and the joint construction by Ibrahim and Ismail.

Surah Ibrahim (14:37) -- Ibrahim's prayer after settling Ismail and his mother Hajar in the valley of Makkah.

Surah Maryam (19:54-55) -- Ismail as a prophet: his character, his message, and his relationship with Allah.

Surah Al-An'am (6:86) -- Ismail listed among the righteous and the prophets.

Surah Al-Anbiya (21:85) -- Ismail among the patient.

Surah Sad (38:48) -- Ismail among the good, mentioned with Zulkifl and Dulkifl.

Surah Al-Baqarah (2:158) -- Safa and Marwa, the hills between which Hajar ran, now part of the Hajj ritual.

Surah Al-Baqarah (2:127-129) -- The prayer of Ibrahim and Ismail after building the Kaaba.

Surah Maryam (19:54) -- "And mention in the Book Ismail. Indeed, he was true to his promise and was a messenger and a prophet."

The Quran does not describe Ismail's birth in detail. The Quranic narrative focuses on Ibrahim's overall story, and Ismail's birth is implied rather than narrated. Islamic tradition fills in the details:

Ibrahim had been married to Sarah for many years without children. Sarah, unable to conceive, offered her Egyptian servant Hajar to Ibrahim as a wife. Hajar conceived and bore Ismail. The name Ismail means "Allah hears" -- a reference to Allah hearing the distress of those who call upon Him.

The Quran's silence on the details of Ismail's birth is consistent with its approach: the focus is not on the circumstances of birth but on the significance of the life. Ismail's birth matters not because of how it happened but because of what followed -- the settlement in Makkah, the sacrifice, the building of the Kaaba, and the lineage that would culminate in Muhammad.

The Quran records one of the most poignant moments in Ibrahim's life -- the settling of Ismail and Hajar in the valley of Makkah:

"Our Lord, I have settled some of my descendants in a valley of no agriculture near Your sacred House, our Lord, that they may establish Prayer. So make hearts among the people incline toward them and provide for them from the fruits, that they may be grateful" (14:37).

This prayer is Ibrahim's explanation and his plea. He has settled his son and his son's mother in a barren valley -- a place with no water, no vegetation, no agriculture, and no people. He has done this because Allah commanded it. And he prays for two things:

That hearts would incline. "Make hearts among the people incline toward them." Ibrahim prays that people would be drawn to this barren valley -- that the desolate place would become a destination. This prayer has been answered beyond anything Ibrahim could have imagined: Makkah is visited by millions every year, and the hearts of Muslims across the world turn toward it five times a day.

That provision would come. "Provide for them from the fruits, that they may be grateful." Ibrahim prays for sustenance in a valley with nothing. He does not ask for luxury; he asks for fruits -- the basic provision that would allow his family to survive and be grateful.

The valley of "no agriculture" -- *wajir ghayri dhi zar'* -- is Makkah. It is a valley surrounded by barren mountains, with no river, no spring, and no rainfall to speak of. Ibrahim left his wife and infant son there with only a bag of dates and a skin of water. When the water ran out, Hajar began to search.

The Quran does not narrate the story of Zamzam directly, but it references the hills of Safa and Marwa -- the sites of Hajar's search:

"Indeed, Safa and Marwa are among the symbols of Allah. So whoever makes Hajj to the House or performs Umrah, there is no blame upon him to walk between them" (2:158).

The tradition, recorded in Sahih Bukhari, fills in the narrative:

When the water ran out, Hajar began to search for help. She climbed the nearest hill -- Safa -- and looked in every direction. Seeing nothing, she descended and climbed the next hill -- Marwa -- and looked again. She ran between the two hills seven times. After the seventh circuit, she heard a sound. An angel had struck the ground, and water gushed forth. Hajar contained the water -- digging around it and saying "Zam! Zam!" -- meaning "stop, stop" or "gather, gather." The well became known as Zamzam.

The Quran's reference to Safa and Marwa as "symbols of Allah" elevates a mother's desperate search for water to the status of a sacred ritual. Every Muslim who performs Hajj or Umrah runs between these two hills, reenacting Hajar's search. The running is not just a physical act; it is a spiritual reenactment of the trust, the desperation, and the hope of a mother who was placed in a barren valley by Allah's command and who refused to give up.

The Quran gives Ismail a distinctive character description in Surah Maryam:

"And mention in the Book Ismail. Indeed, he was true to his promise and was a messenger and a prophet. And he used to enjoin upon his family Prayer and Zakah, and he was to his Lord pleasing" (19:54-55).

Three qualities are highlighted:

True to his promise. *Siddiq al-wa'd* -- truthful in promise. Ismail kept his word. When he committed to something, he fulfilled it. This quality is highlighted because it was tested in the most extreme way: when Ibrahim told him about the dream, Ismail promised to be steadfast -- and he was. His promise was not just words; it was verified by his willingness to lie on the stone and accept the knife.

A messenger and a prophet. Ismail was not just a righteous man or a son of a prophet. He was himself a prophet -- a messenger with his own mission. The Quran gives him this title independently, not as an extension of Ibrahim's prophethood but as his own divine appointment.

He enjoined Prayer and Zakah. Ismail was a leader of his family. He instructed them in the two pillars of Islamic practice: Prayer (the vertical relationship with Allah) and Zakah (the horizontal relationship with people). He was not just a private believer; he was a public teacher who guided his family toward righteousness.

Pleasing to his Lord. *Radiyyan* -- pleased, accepted. Ismail's life was pleasing to Allah. This is the Quran's final assessment -- a one-word summary of a life that included the sacrifice, the building of the Kaaba, the prophethood, and the legacy. He was pleasing. That is enough.

The Quran does not state the genealogical connection between Ismail and Muhammad explicitly, but it is assumed throughout. The Prophet Muhammad was a descendant of Ibrahim through Ismail, through the Arab tribe of Quraysh, through the lineage of Adnan.

The Quran says:

"And We sent down to you the Book in truth, confirming what was before it of the Scripture and as a guardian over it" (5:48).

The Quran is the final revelation, and Muhammad is the final prophet. The connection to Ibrahim through Ismail is the genealogical thread that ties the final revelation back to the original covenant:

"And when his Lord tried Ibrahim with words, and he fulfilled them. He said: I will make you a leader for the people. He said: And of my descendants? He said: My covenant does not include the wrongdoers" (2:124).

The covenant included the righteous descendants. Ismail was righteous. And from Ismail came the lineage that would produce the final messenger. The covenant that Allah made with Ibrahim -- that He would make him a leader for the people -- was fulfilled not just through Ishaq and the Israelite prophets but through Ismail and the Arab line, culminating in Muhammad.

Ismail's significance in the Quran is disproportionate to the number of verses about him. He appears in 12 verses, but his impact on Islamic practice is enormous:

The Kaaba. Ismail helped build it. Every prayer a Muslim offers is directed toward the Kaaba.

The Hajj. The running between Safa and Marwa commemorates his mother's search. The sacrifice of Eid al-Adha commemorates his near-sacrifice.

The Lineage. Ismail is the ancestor of the final prophet. Without Ismail, there is no Muhammad.

The Submission. Ismail's willingness to be sacrificed is the Quran's ultimate example of *islam* -- surrender to Allah. His submission, alongside his father's, defines what it means to be a Muslim.

Ismail is not a secondary figure. He is a central pillar of the Islamic tradition -- a prophet, a builder, a sacrifice, and a father. His story, though told in fragments, assembles into one of the most important narratives in the Quran.